STATE SCAN

MP: THE BIG FAT METRO PARTY *PG 20* **KERALA: A PORTABLE DEAL WITH THE ADANIS** *PG 21*



IANS

FACE-OFF PPCC chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring (right) and former Punjab CM Charanjit Singh Channi, Jun. 24

▶ PUNJAB

PUNJAB'S WARRING FACTIONS

Raja Warring was always seen as a compromise king. Now Channi raises the banner of revolt in the Congress

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

ON JULY 6, ALL EYES IN PUNJAB WERE ON THE PRIZE FIGHT between the Akal Takht and the Bhagwant Mann regime. But no one missed former Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel deboarding quietly in Chandigarh. Officially, it was all ho-hum: the Congress state in-charge was in town to review preparations for the 2027 assembly election. But everyone saw it for what it was, shorn of euphemism. It was the fire engine rushing in, without sirens blaring—there was a full-blown inferno down the block. The high command had reappointed Rahul Gandhi loyalist Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as state unit president, and the state unit was warring against the *firman*.

Days before Baghel's arrival, the mutineers had gathered in Mohali. Their rallying point: former CM Charanjit Singh Channi. Also present was Sukhjinder Randhawa, Gurdaspur MP and AICC general secretary, six of the party's 14 MLAs and a host of biggies. So as to not leave anyone in doubt, they posted pictures from the huddle. A defiant missive to the high